COLLAPSE OF A COACHING CAPITAL

With the government intent on an education that promotes critical thinking rather than the rote learning coaching institutes foster, Kota's already beleaguered coaching industry suffers another blow

By **ROHIT PARIHAR**

IN PANIC MODE
What's killing Kota's Rs 10,000 crore coaching economy

122,000
No. of coaching students in March 2025, a 46 per cent fall from 225,000 in 2022-23

10-30%
Occupancy in PG hostels, barring those in core zones like Talwandi, Rajiv Gandhi Nagar and Indira Vihar, compared to 85-100 per cent earlier

On June 3, coaching centres in Kota—the quiet industrial town on the banks of the Chambal in Rajasthan—proudly celebrated their students' success in national entrance examinations for top engineering colleges. But the mood was subdued, and the celebrations quieter than usual.

The coaching capital of India seems to have lost its mojo in the past few years. Gone are the lanes teeming with students in coaching centre uniforms, the packed restaurants serving burgers, vadas and omelettes, and the 'no vacancy' signs at paying guest (PG) accommodations in coveted neighbourhoods such as Rajiv Gandhi Nagar and Landmark City. Student enrolments are down, as is the revenue of coaching institutes, forcing many of them to shut down unremunerative centres or open new ones in other cities. A spate of student suicides have dealt an additional blow, ending the city's dream run as the coaching capital of the country. With that, the entire ecosystem it had nurtured has also collapsed—the hostels offering PG accommodations, the mess operators providing meals to students and their families, besides the several ancillary services.

A June 17 government order may prove the final nail in the industry's coffin. It calls for a review committee to identify gaps in India's education system that force students to rely on coaching centres, reinforcing the culture of rote learning rather than critical thinking. The committee will also examine the faulty advertising claims by coaching centres, and the unethical practice of enrolling students in 'dummy schools' that game attendance so that students can focus solely on coaching. Kota, once the poster child of this model, may now become a cautionary tale.



"We're staring at a 40% drop in Kota. Allen had 128,000 classroom students in 2022-23. That fell to 90,000 in 2023-24 and is now 65,000"
NAVEEN MAHESHWARI
Director, Allen Career Institute